

ASU Crunches UTEP 15-0

By **MARK LEIBSON**

Times Sports Writer

TEMPE, Ariz. — Most people will look at Arizona State's 15-0 whitewashing of the University of Texas at El Paso and chuckle, "Well, the Miners are at it again. They just can't compete against those WAC schools."

For the most part, it's true. UTEP simply does not possess the hitting, pitching or defense needed to beat the Arizona schools and Friday night's game was no exception.

But there were some distinctive reasons why UTEP looks bad on paper and only fair on the field, especially in the first game of the two schools' current three-game series, which concludes Saturday with a day-night doubleheader.

First, starting pitcher Jerry Walker was in complete control until a line drive bounced off his left knee in the second inning, forcing Coach Andy Cohen to pull the sophomore.

Reliever Mike Rima came in and quickly served up six runs to the Sun Devils the next inning and two-thirds, not allowing himself enough time to warm up.

Second, third baseman Bill Roberts apparently tore a cartledge in his left knee while making a diving catch of a foul ball. His replacement, Brad George, never played third base before and proved it when he fielded a grounder with the bases loaded and threw into the dirt at home in the fifth inning which began ASU's nine-run rally.

UTEP trainer Bobo Robert still had his hands full

an inning later when catcher Jim Bradford separated his shoulder sliding back into first base.

Third, UTEP's pitching staff was already deleted to a bare minimum after Rima, Mike Yeager and Ken Milberger could not keep up with the pace Walker had set earlier in the game. Bruce Dameworth was sidelined with an off-field injury, while Dave Jannusch and Wes Zotz were held out for Saturday's doubleheader.

With nobody in the bullpen, Cohen sent centerfielder Bob Alsup to the mound without any warmup and surprisingly, he was the most effective of all the relievers.

The Miners almost lost the services of Keith Cooper and Terry Dillingham in the bottom of the sixth when they collided at full speed on a fly ball to right-center by ASU's Bobby Horner.

Fortunately, it was the last out of the inning and after UTEP batted in the seventh, the game was called due to the 10-run rule which the home plate umpire had asked Cohen if it could be put into effect.

"Hell, yeah," Cohen told the umpire. "Why not. This is the first time a team of mine has played the 10-run rule. Never in my life have I done it before but we'll do it tonight."

"I'm disappointed and embarrassed," said Cohen. "If Walker hadn't gotten hurt, it might have been a different story."

On the other hand, maybe it wouldn't have been a different ending. Arizona State pitcher Larry Eiler still pitched a three-hitter through seven innings and never allowed a Miner to get past first base.